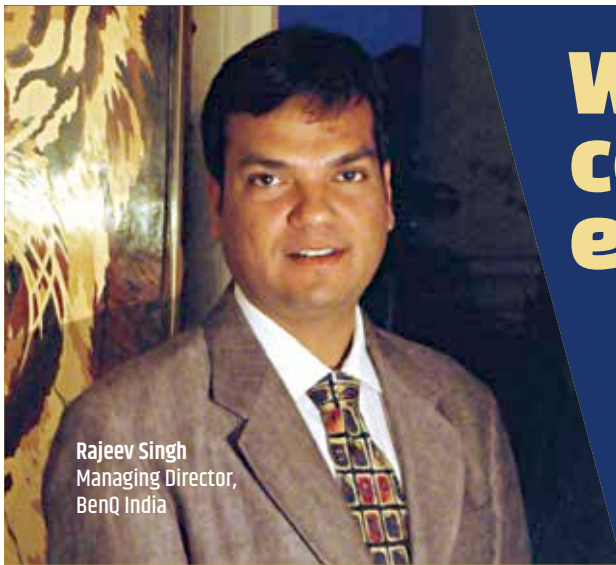




Rajeev Singh
Managing Director,
BenQ India

We're all about competitive esports

We sit down with the MD of BenQ India to understand how Zowie is responding to an increasingly crowded gaming market.

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Q Over the last year, a lot of things have changed. A lot of companies have come on board the whole gaming scene. So how are you going to change your approach?

Rajeev: We're not going to change our approach. The Zowie eXTREMESLAND tournament that we started about a few years back – we felt that CS:GO as a game doesn't really have any proper APAC-level championship. Most of the Zowie hardware is optimised for FPS games because that's where you need the kind of technology that we have to get an edge over your competition. So we decided to invest in an CS:GO based tournament and it's a part of a long term strategy that we have and whatever is happening in India doesn't impact how we are going to go about it. Our idea is very clear. Every year we want to make it a bigger event in terms of how we are conducting the tournament and how many teams are participating, as well as the kind of prize money which is there at the India level as well as at the APAC level. So it continues to grow in that manner. Next year, we're clearly looking at expanding the time horizon that we have for engagement at the India level. Right now it's about 1.5 months, next year it'll be a bit more than 2 months.

Q Aside from CS:GO are there any other games on the horizon that Zowie is going to focus on?

Rajeev: First of all, when it comes to

the tournament part of it, that is where CS:GO is there. As far as our regular business is concerned, we're focused on many games. One such game is PUBG. There's a lot of high quality graphics in such games and we have a series of monitors which are optimised for experiencing such games. That's one of the games we're looking at. Apart from that, we've launched a series of 4K HDR monitors to cater to the console gamers. Console gaming is very different from PC gaming. You have 4K HDR on the PS4 and PS4 Pro along with games that support them. We have a series of monitors for such content as well.

Q Over the last year, we've seen companies that are not focused on peripherals in the Indian market such as GIGABYTE and MSI getting into the peripheral market. How is Zowie changing its strategy in light of this changing market dynamic?

Rajeev: Zowie is a highly focused esports company unlike others. We aren't a gaming company and we're clear on that. We work with esports professionals from all over the world across different genres. We develop our products on the basis of how the games and gameplay are changing. Our product development is about giving gamers an edge over others. So our approach is very different from other brands.

Q In a similar vein about serving the Indian gamers better, product launches in

India are slightly delayed compared to International launches. Are you working on reducing that gap?

Rajeev: In our case, the product launches are almost simultaneous with respect to the worldwide launch. At most, there will be a delay of about a month or two and that's mostly because of the BIS certification process which is applicable to monitors as well. Since that's a regulatory process, we don't have much control over that. Apart from that, we're very much in sync with our worldwide launches.

Q We've started seeing more brands supporting esports teams and some have even completely sponsored esports teams. Is Zowie planning something similar?

Rajeev: First of all, fostering a team is not a part of our strategy. We offer our products for esports and we're focused on competitive gaming only. There are casual gamers who enjoy our products but the Zowie brand is all about competitive esports. We don't wish to limit ourselves to just an inhouse team and we'd rather be there for everyone on the competitive scene.

Q Will there be an eXTREMESLAND for a game other than CS:GO?

Rajeev: There are no such plans as of now. However, it all depends on how the esports ecosystem develops. If a game is progressing well and it matches with our product development philosophy then that's very much possible. **Q**